

INTRODUCTION

The word communication originates from the Latin word "communis", which means "common" and the word business stands for any economic activity which is undertaken with a view to earn profit and the communication undertaken in the process of this activity is termed as "business communication."

Business communication skills are critical to the success of any organization despite its size, geographical location, and its mission. Business communication is interlinked with internal culture and external image of any organization. So it is the determining factor to communication inside the organization.

Good Business communication practices assist the organization in achieving its goal of informing, persuading, favorable relationship, and organizational goodwill. Organizations can only survive if they accept the rapidly changing global challenges and the communication processes are structured and delivered.

DEFINITION

According to **Keith Devis** "Communication is a process of passing information and understanding from one person to another."

According to **Wikipedia** "Communication is generally defined as the activity of conveying information. Communication has been derived from the Latin word "communis", meaning to share.

According to **Wilbur Schramm** "Communication is something people do. To understand human communication process, one must understand how people relate to each other.

MEANING

Communication is defined as "The flow of material information perception, understanding and imagination among various parties".

Business includes those organizations, which are engaged in the production and distribution of goods and services to earn profit. Therefore Business communication means, "Flow of information, perception etc. either within a business organization or outside the organization among different parties".

OBJECTIVES & PURPOSE OF COMMUNICATION

The objectives of business communication would include the following:

- **To give and receive information**

- To provide advice
- To educate and train customer
- To issue orders and instruction
- To persuade target audience
- To receive suggestion
- To motivate and to integrate
- To relate and to entertain

Importance of Business Communication

Persuasion is one of the factors of marketing communications. Persuasion is the main reason companies engage in marketing: to persuade their target audience to take action, as in, buy their product or subscribe to their services, make a phone call, or donate money.

All marketing communication is goal oriented, as the predetermine objective helps to create effective marketing communication strategy. Every successful marketing communications helps plan the marketing message at every contact point.

Importance of Business Communication

- Building a strong bond
- Boosting productivity
- Making informed decisions
- Resolving conflicts
- Improving customer service
- Building a positive image
- Facilitating innovation
- Improving employee engagement
- Managing change
- Ensuring compliance

NATURE OF BUSINESS COMMUNICATION

- It is a process.
- It is inevitable.
- Meaning based.
- Communication could be intentional and unintentional.
- Communication is systematic.
- A two-way traffic.
- Communication is a social process.

- **A dynamic process.**
- **Continuous process.**
- **It is spiraling process.**

Process of Communication

IN COMMUNICATION

1. Sender:

Someone who is sending the message to someone else. For example, in ad the brand being advertised is 'Pantaloons'. Naturally, the maker of this brand is the sender of the advertising message.

2. Encoding:

When we address someone, we use language, visuals, body gestures, etc. to communicate. All these are called symbols. The process of putting our thought into symbolic forms is called encoding. In a following Ad, you see a face full of wrinkles. Then you read the headlines which simply say: "Wrinkle free." This process of communication is called encoding.

3. Message:

The symbols themselves constitute the message. Hence, the visuals, headlines body copy, tag line, brand name, logo, etc., are all parts of the message. If you have already heard the name of 'Pantaloons', then the message being given to you is that are dealing with a known company.

4. Media:

The channels used for sending the message across to the receiver (customer) is called medium (or media; note that media is also singular). This Ad has appeared in the print media (just for the sake of knowledge, TV is an audio-visual medium, radio is an audio medium, etc. You will learn more about media in the second year). An individual member of the medium is called a vehicle. Here, India Today is the vehicle. A vehicle is the carrier of the message.

5. Decoding:

Once we receive the message, we start interpreting it. For example, when you look at the wrinkled face shown in the Ad, you realize how bad it looks. The implication is that your clothes will also look as bad if they were not wrinkle free. Likewise, there are visuals of a shirt and a pair of trouser. These immediately give you the message that the Ad is perhaps for readymade clothes. At the bottom, the message given is that the brand is available at various cities and Pantaloons Shoppes.

6. Receiver:

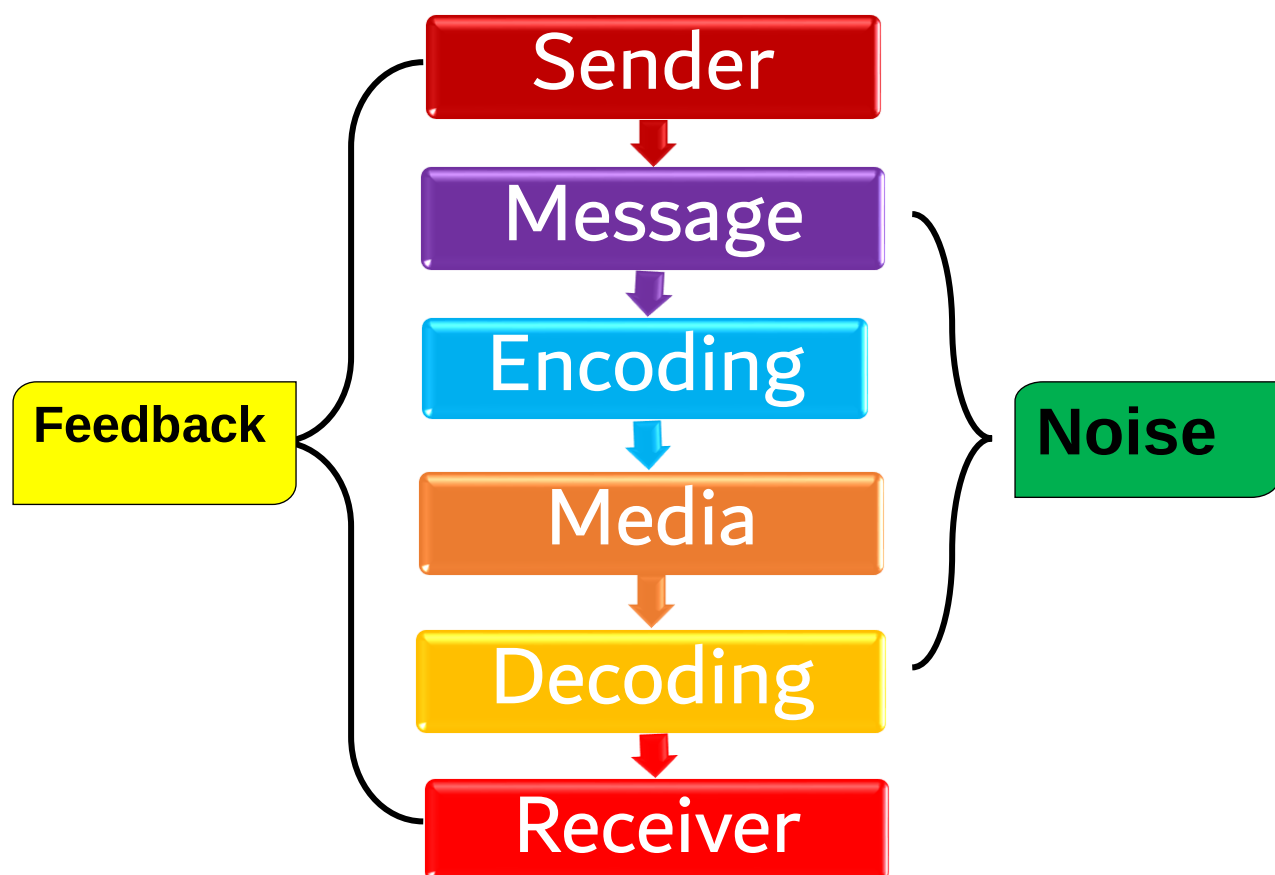
A receiver is one who reads/listen hears the message of the communicator. For example, any reader of India Today who is likely to see this Ad, is the receiver of the message. It may be noted, however, that the communicator (in our example, the manufacturer of Pantaloons) is not interested in just any receiver (i.e. any reader of India Today) but only those who would be interested in using his product. Thus, if never wear trousers, then the company will not be interested in me.

7. Feedback:

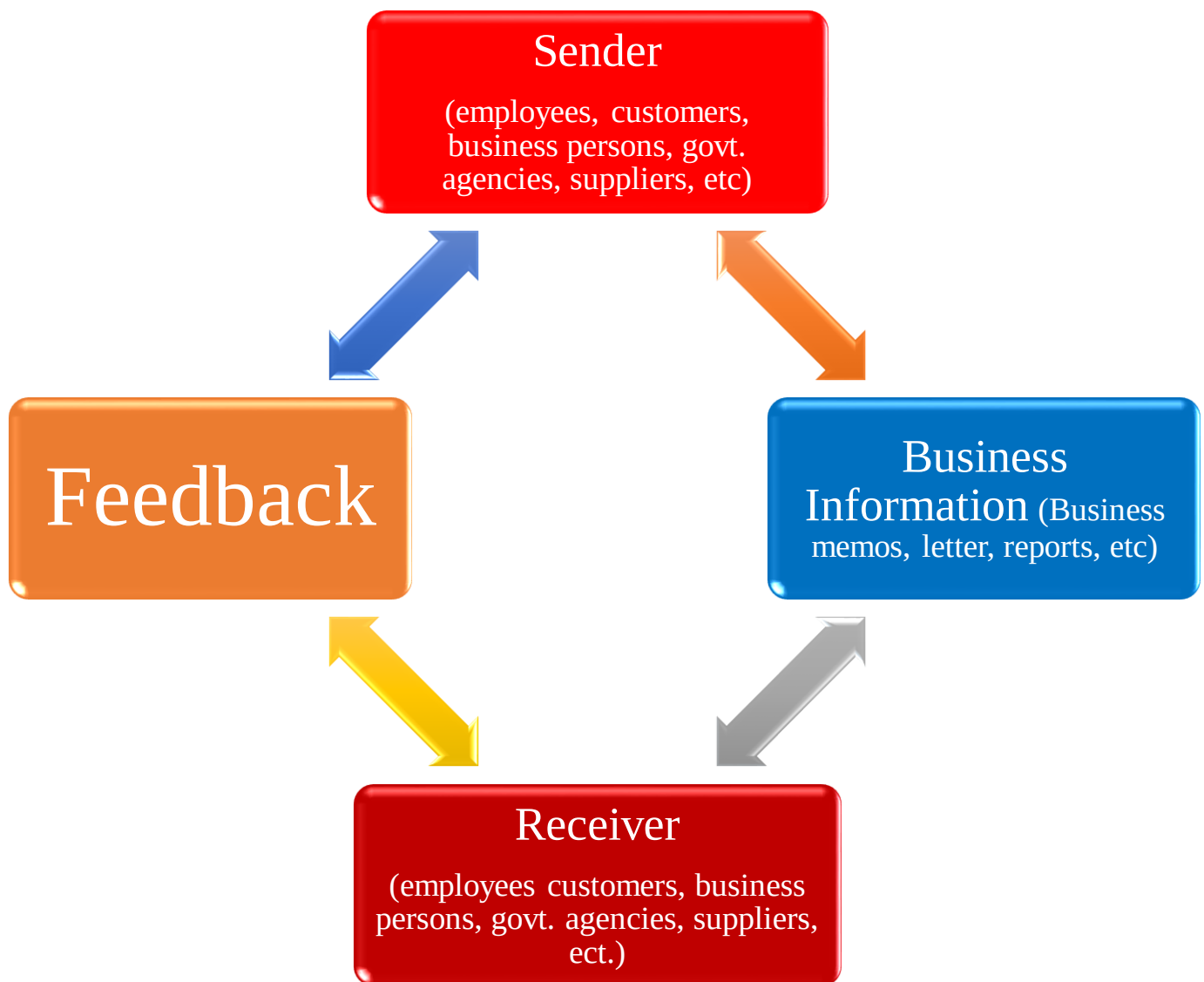
Every communicator waits to know whether the message (a) has reached the target audience or not, and (b) whether it has been accepted or not. In other words, one waits for feedback from the audience. The most desirable form of feedback from the marketer's point of view, of course, would be the purchase of the product by the customers. Thus, after this Ad is released in the media, if the sale of such trousers goes up significantly, the feedback is said to be positive. Similarly, if the company conducts a surveys and questions about the intention to buy; and customers say that they will buy the brand, again, the feedback is positive.

8. Noise:

It refers to any obstruction that is caused by the sender, message or receiver during the process of communication. For example bad telephone connection, faulty encoding, faulty decoding inattentive receiver, poor understanding of message due to prejudice or inappropriate gestures, etc.



IN BUSINESS COMMUNICATION



1. Sender:

The sender refers to the individual, group, or entity that initiates the communication process by transmitting a message. In a business context, the sender could be a manager, employee, team, department, or the organization as a whole. The sender is responsible for encoding the message, selecting the appropriate communication channel, and transmitting it to the intended recipients.

2. Business Information:

Business information consists of data, facts, figures, ideas, or messages that are relevant to the operations, decision-making, or functioning of a business organization. This information could

include letter, business memos, company policies, project updates, customer feedback, or any other data that impacts business activities. Business information is essential for communication within and outside the organization, facilitating informed decision-making and strategic planning.

3. Receiver:

The receiver refers to the individual or group of individuals who receive and interpret the message transmitted by the sender. In business communication, receivers could include managers, employees, clients, customers, suppliers, shareholders, or any other stakeholders with whom the organization interacts. Receivers play a critical role in the communication process by decoding the message, understanding its content and context, and providing feedback or taking appropriate action based on the information received.

4. Feedback:

Feedback is the response or reaction provided by the receiver to the sender after receiving and interpreting the message. It serves as a vital component of the communication process, enabling the sender to gauge the effectiveness of their message and ensuring mutual understanding between the parties involved. Feedback can take various forms, including verbal responses, written replies, questions, suggestions, criticisms, or actions taken based on the information received. In business communication, feedback helps to clarify misunderstandings, resolve issues, improve communication practices, and strengthen relationships between stakeholders.

Functions of Business Communication

- **Helping in Planning**
- **Managing Co – ordination and Co – operation**
- **Initiating Inspiration**
- **Motivating**
- **Helping in Decision Making**
- **Conveying Message**
- **Performance Evaluation**
- **Creating Image**
- **Publicizing Goods and Services**
- **Controlling**



Barriers to Communication

No matter how good the communication system in an organization is, unfortunately barriers can and do often occur. This may be caused by a number of factors which can usually be summarized being as due to physical barrier, languages, and organizational, emotional, personal barriers.

A communication becomes successful only if the receiver understands what the sender is trying to convey. When your message is not clearly understood, you should understand that you should understand that your message is facing a barrier.

Barriers to business communication refer to factors that hinder or obstruct the effective exchange of information, ideas, or messages within an organization. These barriers can occur at various stages of the communication process and may result in misunderstandings, misinterpretations, or incomplete transmission of information. Some common barriers to business communication include:

Commonly Experienced Barriers:

- **Noise**
- **Emotions**
- **Lack of Interest**
- **Loss by Transmission**

- **Conflicts**
- **Improper Time**
- **Physical Distance**
- **Distraction**
- **Discomfortable**
- **Culture, Social and Psychological**
- **Wrong Assumption**
- **Unclearified Matter**
- **Misunderstanding**



Types of Communication Barrier:

Some common barriers are as follows:

- 1. Physical Barrier**
- 2. Semantic Barrier or Language Barrier**
- 3. Cultural Barrier**
- 4. Psychological Barrier or Emotional Barrier**
- 5. Technological Barrier**
- 6. Perceptual Barrier**
- 7. Physiological Barrier**
- 8. Organizational Barrier**

1. Physical Barriers:

These barriers include factors such as distance, noise, poor lighting, or physical distance, information overload, and improper time to communicate. Physical barriers can make it difficult for individuals to communicate effectively, especially in large or crowded spaces.

2. Semantic Barrier:

Semantic barriers is also known as **language barrier**. It arises from differences in language, badly expressed messages, faulty translation, un clarified assumption, specialist language, vocabulary, or interpretation of words and symbols. Misunderstandings can occur due to unfamiliar terminology, ambiguous language, or cultural differences in meaning.

3. Cultural Barrier:

Cultural barriers result from differences in cultural norms, values, beliefs, use of voice, concept of space, concept time, social relationship, and communication styles among individuals or groups from different cultural backgrounds. These differences can lead to misinterpretations, stereotypes, or conflicts in communication.

4. Psychological Barrier:

Psychological barriers is also known as **emotional barrier**. It stem from individual perceptions, attitudes, listening barrier, emotions, or mental states that influence communication. Factors such as stress, anxiety, fear, or personal biases can impede effective communication and hinder understanding.

5. Technological Barrier:

Technological barriers arise from issues related to the use of communication technology, such as equipment malfunctions, connectivity problems, or software glitches. Inadequate training or lack of familiarity with communication tools can also hinder effective communication.

6. Perceptual Barrier:

A perceptual barrier in communication occurs when individuals perceive and interpret information differently due to their personal experiences, beliefs, attitudes, or biases. These differences can lead to misunderstandings, misinterpretations, and ineffective communication. Overcoming perceptual barriers often requires empathy, active listening, and the ability to see things from others' perspectives.

7. Physiological Barrier:

It's important to accommodate the specific needs of individuals with disabilities or limitations. This may involve using assistive technologies, providing alternative communication methods, speaking clearly and at a moderate pace, and being patient and supportive during interactions. Creating an inclusive environment that respects the diverse needs of all individuals can help promote effective communication despite physiological barriers.

8. Organizational Barrier:

Organizational barriers in communication refer to obstacles that arise within the structure, culture, or processes of an organization that hinder effective communication. These barriers can include hierarchical structures that impede the flow of information, unclear communication channels, bureaucratic policies, lack of transparency, and competing priorities within the organization. Overcoming organizational barriers often involves promoting open communication, flattening hierarchies where possible, implementing clear communication protocols, and fostering a culture that values transparency and collaboration.

Removal of Communication Barriers

- **Use simple and clear language.**
- **Pay attention to non – verbal cause. Such as body language, tone or voice, facial expression.**
- **Be aware of cultural differences and try to accommodate them in your communication style.**
- **Repeat and clarify messages to ensure mutual understanding.**
- **Be an active listener and seek clarification when necessary.**
- **Use visual aids, diagram and other forms of media to aid communication.**
- **Build rapport and trust with the person you are communicating with the foster open and honest communication.**

- **Providing feedback and increase feedback from other to ensure effective communication.**

Removal of Business Communication Barrier

- **Use Technology to facilitation communication.**
- **Provide training and education.**
- **Develop a common language.**
- **Increate feedback and open communication.**
- **Forster or causative and inclusive.**
- **Use translation and interpretation services.**
- **Build relationship.**

Removing barriers in communication is crucial for effective and efficient interaction among individuals or groups. Here are several strategies to overcome communication barriers:

- **Active Listening**
- **Clear and Concise Messaging**
- **Non-verbal Communication**
- **Empathy and Understanding**
- **Feedback Mechanisms**
- **Training and Education**
- **Technology and Tools**
- **Addressing Language Barriers**
- **Creating a Supportive Environment**
- **Continuous Improvement**

Verbal Communication

Verbal communication is the transmission of messages or information using spoken words. It is one of the most common forms of communication and plays a central role in human interaction, allowing individuals to convey ideas, share thoughts, exchange information, and express feelings.

Verbal communication is the use of speech to convey messages between individuals or groups. It is an essential skill for effective communication in personal and professional settings. Some examples of verbal communication are:

Conversations:

This is the most common form of verbal communication, where two or more people exchange information, opinions, feelings, or ideas through spoken words. Conversations can be formal or informal, depending on the context and the relationship between the participants.

Presentations:

This is a type of verbal communication where one person delivers a speech or a lecture to an audience, usually with the help of visual aids such as slides, charts, or videos. Presentations are usually meant to inform, persuade, or entertain the listeners.

Interviews:

This is a type of verbal communication where one person asks questions and another person answers them, usually for the purpose of assessing the suitability of the latter for a job, a role, or a project. Interviews can be structured or unstructured, depending on the level of flexibility and direction given by the interviewer.

Debates:

This is a type of verbal communication where two or more people present opposing arguments or viewpoints on a topic, usually in front of an audience or a judge. Debates are usually meant to test the logic, evidence, and persuasion skills of the speakers.

Storytelling:

This is a type of verbal communication where one person narrates a story or an anecdote, usually to entertain, educate, or inspire the listeners. Storytelling can be oral or written, depending on the medium and the style of the storyteller.

Verbal communication involves the exchange of thoughts, feelings and ideas using spoken words. Its effectiveness depends upon various aspects, including the choice of words, tone and clarity of speech. It is a two-way process in which the speaker transmits information while the listener comprehends and interprets the message.

Five Types of Verbal Communication

1. Intrapersonal Verbal Communication

Intrapersonal communication is our internal dialogue. We all do this. Often without realizing it, we talk to ourselves or have conversations with others in our head. This type of verbal communication is also referred to as inner speech, self-talk, internal discourse and inner experience.

2. Interpersonal Verbal Communication

Interpersonal verbal communication involves two parties. Like speaking one-on-one with a friend or colleague. It evolves using spoken words, listening when the other person is talking, understanding what is being said and responding accordingly.

3. Group Verbal Communication

This is where more than three people are involved in a conversation. There may be more people this time but the same rules apply as with interpersonal communication. Each person has a chance to speak, while others listen and respond at the right time.

4. Public Verbal Communication

Public verbal communication can be anything from speaking aloud at a school assembly to being a keynote speaker at a conference. It's communicating to an audience of people, who have come to hear what you have to say. This form of verbal communication takes some people completely out of their comfort zone. But, developing this communication skill can also open new opportunities.

5. Mass Verbal Communication

This is all about talking to the masses. So, think about a TV show with a panel of experts, or a podcast where thousands of listeners tune in at the same time. Mass verbal communication involves a small group of speakers, who work as a team to share views and ideas with their audience.

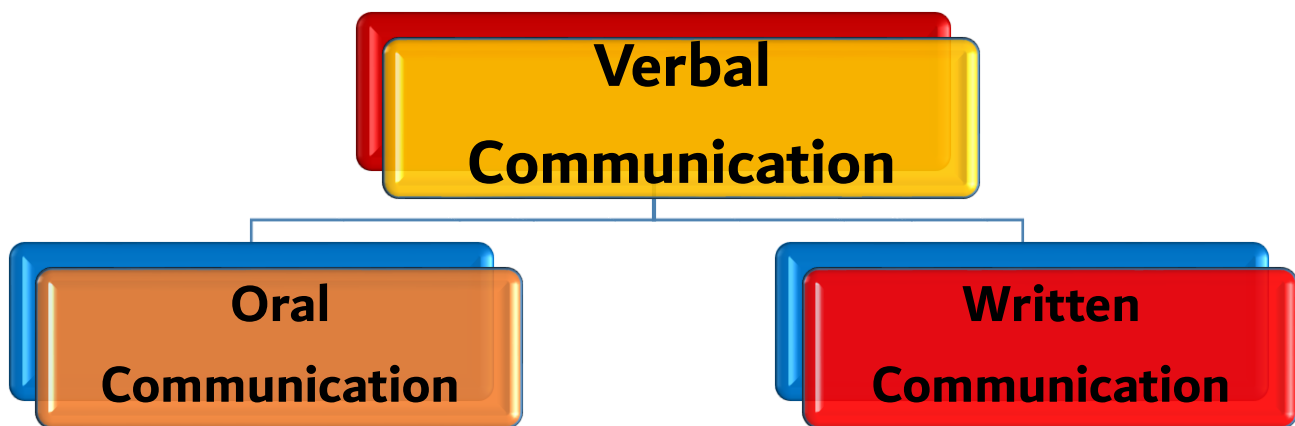
Advantages of Verbal communication

- **Immediate Feedback**
- **Richness of Context**
- **Personal Connection**
- **Flexibility**
- **Immediate Resolution of Issues**
- **Effective for Complex Information**
- **Facilitates Collaboration**
- **Builds Trust and Rapport**
- **Enhances Learning**
- **Cultural and Social Connection**

Disadvantages of Verbal communication

- **Lack of Permanent Record**
- **Limited Retention**
- **Misinterpretation**
- **Lack of Clarity**
- **Difficulty in Complex Information**
- **Inefficiency**
- **Limited Reach**
- **Potential for Distortion**
- **Difficulty in Formality**

Two measure Types of Verbal Communication



Oral Communication

Oral communication refers to the process of exchanging information, thoughts, ideas, or feelings through spoken words. It is a vital aspect of human interaction, allowing individuals to convey messages, express emotions, and build relationships through verbal means. Oral communication can occur in various forms, including face-to-face conversations, telephone conversations, presentations, speeches, interviews, and group discussions.

Oral communication plays a crucial role in business communication. It involves the exchange of information, ideas, and messages through spoken words, whether in face-to-face conversations, meetings, presentations, telephone calls, or video conferences. Effective oral communication skills are essential for building relationships, resolving conflicts, making decisions, and achieving organizational goals.

Advantages of Oral Communication

- **Time Saving**
- **Reduction of cost**
- **Effective for all (Illiterate)**
- **Quick Feedback**
- **Personal Connection**
- **Flexibility and Adaptability**
- **Immediate Clarification**
- **Quick Decision Making**

Disadvantages of Oral Communication

- **No Record**
- **Misunderstanding**
- **Distorted Meaning**
- **Lack of Accuracy**
- **No Legal Validity**
- **Lack of Clarity**
- **Limited Reach**
- **Language Barriers**
- **Distractions and Interruptions**

Written Communication

Written communication is another critical aspect of business communication, complementing oral communication. It involves conveying information, ideas, instructions, and messages through written mediums such as emails, memos, reports, letters, proposals, and presentations.

Written communication refers to the process of conveying information, ideas, thoughts, or messages through written symbols or words. It involves using written language, such as letters, emails, reports, memos, articles, or other written documents, to communicate with others. Written communication can take various forms, including formal or informal, depending on the context and audience. It allows for the exchange of information across distances and time, providing a permanent record that can be referenced later. Written communication often requires careful consideration of language, grammar, punctuation, and formatting to ensure clarity and effectiveness in conveying the intended message. It plays a crucial role in various aspects of personal, academic, professional, and social interactions.

Written communication in business communication refers to the exchange of information, ideas, instructions, or messages through written formats within a business or organizational context. It involves the use of written words, documents, reports, memos, emails, letters, manuals, proposals, contracts, and other written materials to convey messages between individuals or groups within or outside the organization.

Advantages of Written Communication

- **Permanent Record**
- **Clarity**
- **Ease in Verification**

- **Serve as Legal Record**
- **Facilitation of Complex Ideas**
- **Flexibility in Timing**
- **Reduced Misinterpretation**
- **Accessibility**
- **Cost-Effectiveness**

Disadvantages of Written Communication

- **Expensive**
- **Time-consuming**
- **Lack of Immediate Feedback**
- **Potential for Misinterpretation**
- **Difficulty in Conveying Emotion**
- **Limited Feedback Mechanisms**
- **Potential for Information Overload**
- **Dependency on Literacy Skills**
- **Security Risks**

Non Verbal Communication

Nonverbal communication refers to the transmission of messages or information without the use of words. Instead, it relies on gestures, body language, facial expressions, eye contact, posture, tone of voice, and other nonverbal cues to convey meaning, emotions, and intentions. Nonverbal communication often complements verbal communication and can significantly impact how a message is interpreted and understood.

Advantages of Non Verbal Communication

- **Reduce Wastage of Time**
- **Quick Transmission of Message**
- **Effective**
- **Enhances Understanding**
- **Conveys Emotions**
- **Conveys Confidence and Competence**
- **Cross-cultural Communication**
- **Provides Subtleties**
- **Enhances Persuasion**
- **Nonverbal Cues in Relationships**

Disadvantages of Non Verbal Communication

- **Might Distort Information**
- **Meaning Varies Across Cultures**
- **Long Conversation is not Possible**
- **Difficulty in Long-Distance Communication**
- **Limited Accessibility**
- **Emotional Leakage**

Functions of Non Verbal Communication

- **Repeating** (Saying OK with your hands and verbally)
- **Complementing** ("I love you" in a monotone voice)
- **Substituting** ("What's Up" with a head nod)
- **Accenting** (Emphasizes verbal message, "It was YOUR idea", while pointing a finger)
- **Regulating** (Nodding head in a conversation)
- **Contradicting** ("I'm NOT yelling" while yelling)
- **Deceiving** (leakage/lying; fingers crossed behind back)

Five Principles of Non-verbal Communication

- ✓ **Continuous**
- ✓ **Multichannel**
- ✓ **Conscious / Intentional**
- ✓ **Unconscious / Unintentional**
- ✓ **Ambiguous and can occur both face to face and through mediated platforms**

Uses of Non-verbal Communication because

- **Words have limitation.**
- **Non-verbal signals are powerful.**
- **Non-verbal communication or messages are lightly to more genuine.**
- **Non-verbal signal can express feeling in appropriate to state.**
- **A separate communication channel is necessary to help in sending complex messages.**

Note:- According to research the only 7% of messages are sent through words. The remaining 93 % sent or communicate through non-verbal communication.

Two category of Non-verbal communication

Kinesics: (Body movement, gesture, posture)

Proxemics: (Physical distance)

1. Kinesics

This important the most often studied and important area of non-verbal communication and refers to body movements of any kind of different body movements can express inner states of emotion.

Facial expression can convey feelings and of surprise, happiness anger and sadness. For example: If you meet a long lost friend and say "I'm very happy meet you again", but with a sad facial expression, It conveys the exact opposite meaning.

Eye Movements, such as wide open pupils, express feelings of surprise, excitement or even fear. The importance of eye contact with one's audience was pointed out earlier. Direct eye contact is an indication of intensity and interest, while lack of it can convey feelings of nervousness and guilt.

Gestures, such as movement of the hands while giving a lecture or presentation, indicates a high level of involvement in what you are saying. On the other hand, shuffling of the feet is a sign of nervousness and speaking with one's hands in one's pockets is considered to be casual or even rude.

Head Movements, like nodding the head can convey interest, appreciation, agreement or understanding.

Body Shape and Posture - Body shape is not within one's control, but can be stereotyped to convey certain meanings. For example, someone who is strong and muscular is generally thought to be athletic, as opposed to a person who is short and fat!

Posture on the other hand, is within our control. In formal settings such as job interviews or classroom settings, it is essential that you maintain an erect posture to convey that you are attentive, since slouching or a relaxed posture conveys a casual attitude.

Physical Appearance - Our outward appearance, including the way we dress and the jewelry and make-up that we wear can convey an impression of formality or informality. Going

to a job interview dressed in blue jeans, or not sticking to a stipulated dress code at the workplace can convey that you are a rebel, non-conformist or a very casual person.

Therefore, it is important to take care of your appearance, so that you convey the right meaning to others.

2. Proxemics

Proxemics is derived from the word "proximity" or closeness and is the communication term for personal space and distance. **The space and distance which we choose to keep from people** is also part of non-verbal communication. Each of us has our own inner and outer circles, which differ for different people.

Our inner most circle is an "**intimate space**", into which we generally admit only select people such as family and close friends. Next comes a "**personal space**" which might include other friends and colleagues or co-workers. These two spaces involve communication of an informal nature.

Most of us also have a "**social and public**" **space**, which includes official or workplace relationships, where the communication is of a more formal nature.

In a business context, it is more relevant to understand the concept of "**fixed space**" and "**semi-fixed**" **space**.

Fixed space means that the physical features of the work environment such as furniture, room size and seating arrangement are permanent. This conveys an impression of formality. On the other hand, semi-fixed space means that certain elements of the environment can be changed for example, the seating arrangement could be changed and this conveys an impression of informality.

Sometimes, use of space at the workplace can determine leadership positions. For example, seating at the head of the table conveys leadership or authority. A round table meeting, however, conveys the idea of equality, since no one can be seated at the head of the table! All points of a circle are the same. That is why when heads of state meet (as in UN Security Council meetings), it is always a round table discussion, since all heads are equal.

Negative Body Language

- **Poor Stance**
- **Avoiding Eye Contact**
- **Being Clumsy with Objects**
- **In Appropriate Spacing**

- Sweating
- Frowning (Aggressive Behaviour)
- Over using of Gestures

55 | 38 | 7 Elements of Personal Communication

According to a body language researcher “**Albert Mehrabain**”

55 % =Nonverbal = Body Language

38 % =Voice = Tone

7 % =Words = Spoken

According to Albert Mehrabain nonverbal communication is

3 V's of communication

- a) Visual
- b) Vocal, Sound, Volume
- c) Verbal

Types of Nonverbal Communication

The many different types of nonverbal communication or body language include:

1. Facial expressions:

The human face is extremely expressive, able to convey countless emotions without saying a word. And unlike some forms of nonverbal communication, facial expressions are universal. The facial expressions for happiness, sadness, anger, surprise, fear, and disgust are the same across cultures.

2. Body movement and posture

Consider how your perceptions of people are affected by the way they sit, walk, stand, or hold their head. The way you move and carry yourself communicates a wealth of information to the world. This type of nonverbal communication includes your posture, bearing, stance, and the subtle movements you make.

3. Gestures

Gestures are woven into the fabric of our daily lives. You may wave, point, beckon, or use your hands when arguing or speaking animatedly, often expressing yourself with gestures without thinking. However, the meaning of some gestures can be very different across cultures. While the "OK" sign made with the hand, for example, usually conveys a positive message in English-speaking countries, it's considered offensive in countries such as Germany, Russia, and Brazil. So, it's important to be careful of how you use gestures to avoid misinterpretation.

4. Eye contact

Since the visual sense is dominant for most people, eye contact is an especially important type of nonverbal communication. The way you look at someone can communicate many things, including interest, affection, hostility, or attraction. Eye contact is also important in maintaining the flow of conversation and for gauging the other person's interest and response.

5. Touch

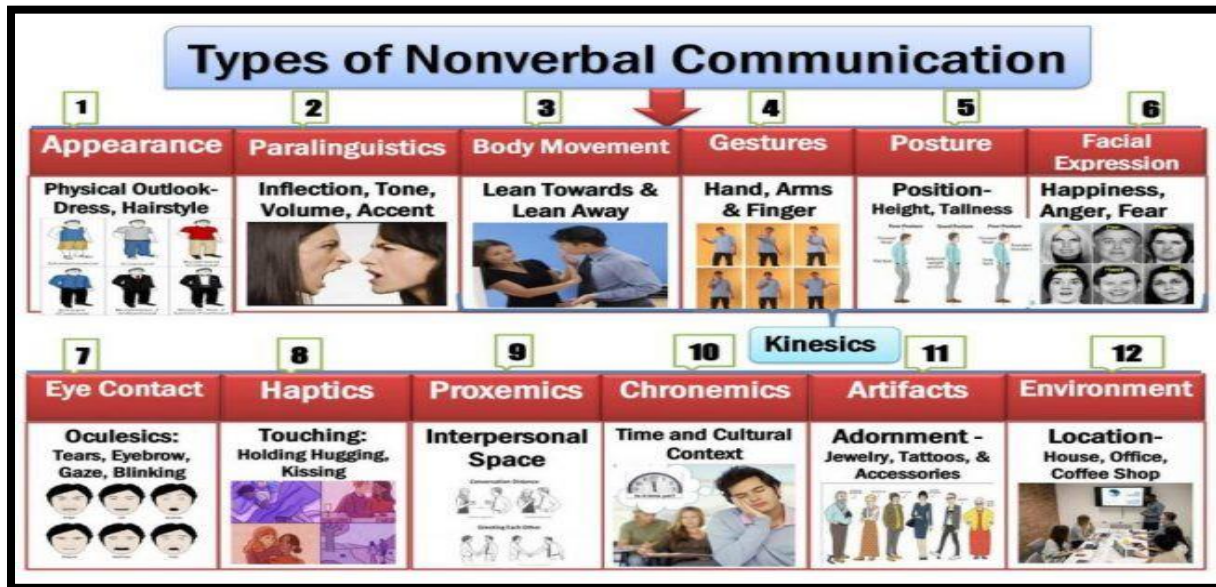
We communicate a great deal through touch. Think about the very different messages given by a weak handshake, a warm bear hug, a patronizing pat on the head, or a controlling grip on the arm, for example.

6. Space

Have you ever felt uncomfortable during a conversation because the other person was standing too close and invading your space? We all have a need for physical space, although that need differs depending on the culture, the situation, and the closeness of the relationship. You can use physical space to communicate many different nonverbal messages, including signals of intimacy and affection, aggression or dominance.

7. Voice

It's not just what you say, it's how you say it. When you speak, other people "read" your voice in addition to listening to your words. Things they pay attention to include your timing and pace, how loud you speak, your tone and inflection, and sounds that convey understanding, such as "ahh" and "uh-huh." Think about how your tone of voice can indicate sarcasm, anger, affection, or confidence.



How to improve nonverbal communication

Nonverbal communication is a rapidly flowing back-and-forth process that requires your full focus on the moment-to-moment experience. If you're planning what you're going to say next, checking your phone, or thinking about something else, you're almost certain to miss nonverbal cues and not fully understand the subtleties of what's being communicated. As well as being fully present, you can improve how you communicate nonverbally by learning to manage stress and developing your emotional awareness.

Learn to manage stress in the moment

Stress compromises your ability to communicate. When you're stressed out, you're more likely to misread other people, send confusing or off-putting nonverbal signals, and lapse into unhealthy knee-jerk patterns of behavior. And remember: emotions are contagious. If you are upset, it is very likely to make others upset, thus making a bad situation worse.

If you're feeling overwhelmed by stress, take a time out. Take a moment to calm down before you jump back into the conversation. Once you've regained your emotional equilibrium, you'll feel better equipped to deal with the situation in a positive way.

The fastest and surest way to calm yourself and manage stress in the moment is to employ your senses-what you see, hear, smell, taste, and touch-or through a soothing movement. By viewing a photo of your child or pet, smelling a favorite scent, listening to a certain piece of music, or squeezing a stress ball, for example, you can quickly relax and refocus. Since everyone responds differently, you may need to experiment to find the sensory experience that works best for you.

Develop your emotional awareness

In order to send accurate nonverbal cues, you need to be aware of your emotions and how they influence you. You also need to be able to recognize the emotions of others and the true feelings behind the cues they are sending. This is where emotional awareness comes in.

Being emotionally aware enables you to:

- ✓ Accurately read other people, including the emotions they're feeling and the unspoken messages they're sending.
- ✓ Create trust in relationships by sending nonverbal signals that match up with your words.
- ✓ Respond in ways that show others that you understand and care.

Many of us are disconnected from our emotions-especially strong emotions such as anger, sadness, fear-because we've been taught to try to shut off our feelings. But while you can deny or numb your feelings, you can't eliminate them. They're still there and they're still affecting your behavior. By developing your emotional awareness and connecting with even the unpleasant emotions, though, you'll gain greater control over how you think and act. To start developing your emotional awareness, practice the mindfulness meditation in HelpGuide's free Emotional Intelligence Toolkit.

How to read body language

Once you've developed your abilities to manage stress and recognize emotions, you'll start to become better at reading the nonverbal signals sent by others. It's also important to:

Pay attention to inconsistencies. Nonverbal communication should reinforce what is being said. Is the person saying one thing, but their body language conveying something else? For example, are they telling you "yes" while shaking their head no?

Look at nonverbal communication signals as a group. Don't read too much into a single gesture or nonverbal cue. Consider all of the nonverbal signals you are receiving, from eye contact to tone of voice and body language. Taken together, are their nonverbal cues consistent or inconsistent-with what their words are saying?

Trust your instincts. Don't dismiss your gut feelings. If you get the sense that someone isn't being honest or that something isn't adding up, you may be picking up on a mismatch between verbal and nonverbal cues.

Evaluating nonverbal signals

Eye contact –is the person making eye contact? If so, is it overly intense or just right?

Facial expression – What is their face showing? Is it masklike and unexpressive, or emotionally present and filled with interest?

Tone of voice – Does the person's voice project warmth, confidence, and interest, or is it. Strained and blocked?

Posture and gesture –is their body relaxed or stiff and immobile? Are their shoulders tense and raised, or relaxed?

Touch –Is there any physical contact? Is it appropriate to the situation? Does it make you feel uncomfortable?

Intensity –Does the person seem flat, cool, and disinterested, or over-the-top and melodramatic?

Timing and place –Is there an easy flow of information back and forth? Do nonverbal responses come too quickly or too slowly?

Sounds –Do you hear sounds that indicate interest, caring or concern from the person?